

## START HERE

## So you just got adjusted. Now what?

*A short, no-nonsense guide to the hours and days after a chiropractic visit — what is normal, what is not, and what nobody bothered to tell you.*

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A short read · About 5 minutes · **For patients in active care**

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Most people walk out of a chiropractic office feeling pretty good. The neck moves better. The lower back feels lighter. Things that were locked down five minutes ago are not anymore. So far, so good.

Then around hour four, something happens. Maybe a deep ache shows up between the shoulder blades. Maybe a strange tired feeling sets in. Maybe everything feels totally fine and they wonder if they just paid for nothing.

All of this is normal. The reason it is normal is the part nobody bothered to explain. Here it is.

### 01 Why the body reacts at all

An adjustment is a small, fast input to a joint that was stuck. The point is to restore motion and let the nervous system reset. That reset is not a passive event. The body has to *do* something with the new information.

Imagine taking a watch that has not run in years and giving it a gentle shake. The hands start moving. Tiny gears that have been still for a long time begin turning. There is going to be some clicking and whirring before everything settles. Bodies are like this too — only a watch does not have muscles, fluid, and a nervous system that has opinions about being moved.



*A common after-adjustment arc. Not everyone goes through all three stages — some skip straight to feeling great.*

## 02 What is normal in the first 24 hours

Most reactions in the first day fall into one of a few buckets. None of them are cause for concern.

Right after

**Looser, lighter, taller.** The classic post-adjustment feel. Patients describe it as "easier to breathe" or "I forgot my neck was supposed to do that." This can last anywhere from a few hours to the rest of the day.

2–6 hours later

**A mild ache or "worked-out" feeling.** Similar to the day after a yoga class. The muscles around an adjusted joint are not used to that range yet, so they speak up. Usually rates between 1 and 3 out of 10. Comes and goes.

That evening

**Tired, hungry, or oddly emotional.** The nervous system uses energy to recalibrate. Some patients sleep deeply that night. Some get unusually hungry. A few feel weirdly sentimental for an hour. All within the range of normal.

Next morning

**A little stiff, then better than before.** Stiffness on first standing usually clears within a few minutes of moving around. By mid-morning, things tend to feel more open than they did pre-adjustment.

Day 2

**Settled.** If the body had a strong response, this is when it tends to even out. Doing the prescribed home exercises matters here — that is what tells the nervous system to *keep* the new pattern.

### IN PLAIN TERMS

Some soreness is the body's way of acknowledging it just had to do something new. It is a sign of change, not a sign of damage.

### 03 What helps in the hours after

Almost none of this requires effort. Most of it is about what *not* to do.

**Drink water.** A reasonable amount. Not gallons. Discs and connective tissue in the spine are mostly water, and they tend to do better when fed.

**Move a little.** A short walk does more than lying on the couch. The nervous system learns the new pattern by using it. Sitting motionless for six hours after an adjustment is a missed opportunity.

**Skip the heavy lifting today.** The joint that was just freed is also a little more mobile than usual. That is the point. But max-effort deadlifts on the same afternoon are asking for trouble. Save them for tomorrow.

**Heat for muscles, ice for sharp pain.** If the soreness feels like a workout, heat helps. If something feels sharp or inflamed, ice is the better call. Twenty minutes either way.

**Sleep.** Boring advice and the most underrated. The nervous system does most of its filing overnight.

### 04 What is not normal — call the office

Most after-adjustment reactions are not worth a phone call. A small number are. Knowing the difference is the only thing on this whole page that really matters.

Call the office if you notice

- **Sharp, stabbing pain** that is new since the adjustment and not improving after a few hours.
- **Numbness, tingling, or weakness** in an arm or leg that was not there before.
- **Pain that wakes you up at night** or stops you from finding any comfortable position.
- **A new headache** that is severe, sudden, or unlike anything familiar.
- **Dizziness, vision changes, or trouble with speech** — these are uncommon but warrant a call right away.

None of these things mean something is broken. They mean the doctor wants to take another look and adjust the plan. That is a normal part of care, not a failure of it.

*Soreness that feels like a workout is normal. Pain that feels sharp, electric, or wrong is not. Nobody is ever annoyed by a patient calling to ask.*

### 05 What if nothing happens at all

About one in four patients walks out of an adjustment feeling... roughly the same. No dramatic relief. No soreness. Just normal. They sometimes wonder if it worked.

It probably did. A lot of the work an adjustment does is invisible in the moment — restoring motion to a joint, easing tension in the surrounding muscles, sending a quiet update to the nervous system. The body does not always announce these changes. Especially in patients who have been in care for a while, the visit feels routine because that is what consistent care looks like. The dramatic responses tend to come at the beginning, when there is more to undo.

The honest test is not how the next twenty minutes feel. It is how the body moves over the next few weeks.

## 06 The bottom line

Most reactions to an adjustment are mild, short-lived, and a sign the body is integrating something new. A small handful are worth calling about. The list above covers the ones that matter.

Drink water. Move a little. Sleep. Do the home practice. And if anything feels sharp, electric, or unlike normal soreness — pick up the phone. That is what the office is there for.

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**About this guide.** This is general patient education and is not medical advice for any specific person. Reactions to chiropractic care vary, and any concerns about a specific symptom should go directly to the treating chiropractor or a relevant medical provider. If symptoms feel like a medical emergency, call 911 or go to the nearest emergency department.